



Designing Playful AI Activities

A design thinking lens for the sprint

*After IDEO's design thinking process
Playful Programming and Algorithmic Intelligence*

You are about to design for humans

Not for a curriculum. Not for a learning objective.

For a specific class, on a specific Tuesday afternoon, in a specific room.

“ *"The main tenet of design thinking is empathy for the people you're trying to design for."*

— David Kelley, IDEO

”

Your students are the people. This hour gives you the moves.

The rhythm underneath everything

IDEO describe the core rhythm as **creating choices and making choices**.

Creating choices — go wide. Many bad ideas, fast.

Making choices — narrow. Commit to one and build it.

Most failed activity design is a team that **never went wide**, or one that **never committed**.

Watch which one you are doing today.

Seven phases, not a checklist

IDEO compare the phases to ingredients in a recipe: structure to start with, improvisation once you know them.

You will move between them messily. That is correct.

But you should be able to say, at any moment, **which one you are in.**

1 • Frame the question

Start with "How might we..."

Not: *"I want to teach classification."*

But: **"How might we help students notice that a machine's confidence tells them nothing about its accuracy?"**

The move is to define the challenge before reaching for solutions — which keeps the design space open long enough for a good idea to arrive.

Your first ten minutes: write three "How might we" questions. Pick one.

2 • Gather inspiration

Your students are the research

You already have the field data. Use it deliberately:

- Where did your class get confused last term?
- What do they already believe about AI, wrongly?
- What made them lean forward this year? What made them reach for their phones?

Understanding people and context is what fuels insight.

Ten minutes. Write down three real things about the actual class you are designing for.

3 • Synthesize for action

Find the one idea worth building around

Sort, cluster, and connect what you noticed until themes appear.

Look at your three student observations and your "How might we".

Name the single concept your activity will carry. One. Not four.

An activity that teaches one thing well beats one that gestures at everything.

4 • Generate ideas

Go wide before you fall in love

Twelve minutes. Aim for **eight rough ideas**, not one good one.

Forcing moves when you stall:

- What if it were entirely unplugged?
- What if students had to *break* it?
- What if the AI played a character?
- What if the wrong answer was the point?

Wide exploration is what expands the range of possible solutions.

Then converge: pick one. Kill the rest without mourning.

5 • Make ideas tangible

Build the roughest thing that can be tried

Not a lesson plan. A **playable version**.

Paper, sticky notes, a half-working p5 sketch, one slide, a prompt typed into a chat window — whatever makes the idea testable in the next hour.

You learn fastest when an idea takes shape in the world.

Rough is a feature. Polished prototypes make testers polite.

6 • Test to learn

The playtest is the point

Another group plays your activity as your students — including the awkward ones.

Testing is what reveals what works, what does not, and what needs another pass.

Your job while they play: **say nothing, write everything.**

Every place you had to explain something is a place the design failed, not the tester.

7 • Share the story

And then: October

The final phase is articulating the need, the process, and the value in a way others can act on.

Two audiences:

Your students, in the weeks between now and 5 October.

This room, when you come back and tell us what actually happened.

The real test is not the playtest. **It is your classroom.**

Today's timebox

Frame + Gather → 20 min

Synthesize → 10 min

Generate → 15 min

Make tangible → 45 min

Test → 30 min

Go wide first. Commit hard after.